

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MOZAMBIQUE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide uses the Mozambican terms and bodies you'll actually run into — the DUAT, occupation in good faith, the consulta comunitária, the three-stage Licença Ambiental and its categories, the EPDA, the Plano de Reassentamento — and explains each in plain words the first time. The rules are amended periodically and the responsible ministry has been renamed, so check the current instruments.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Between Mozambique, Brazil, and Japan, three governments planned one of the largest agribusiness land grabs in African history: **ProSAVANA**, a scheme to turn up to **14 million hectares** of the **Nacala Corridor** — the most densely populated farming region of northern Mozambique — into vast monocrop plantations of soy, maize, and cotton for export, on land where millions of peasant families lived and grew their food. It was decided from the top, behind closed doors, with almost no consultation of the people it would displace. And it was **stopped by those people**. When the draft master plan leaked in 2013, Mozambique's national peasant union, **UNAC**, and its civil-society allies built something unprecedented: a **transnational movement** spanning all three countries — peasants, NGOs, academics, and churches in Mozambique, Brazil, and Japan — that studied the plan, exposed it, marched against it, and handed an open letter demanding its cancellation directly to the Japanese prime minister. Under that sustained, coordinated pressure, ProSAVANA lost its backers and collapsed. A peasant movement had killed a three-government mega-project.

UNAC and its civil-society allies — the peasant movement that killed ProSAVANA across three countries — drew on a genuinely strong toolkit rooted in land. Under the Land Law, a community or family acquires a **DUAT** — a land-use and benefit right — simply by **occupying land in good faith or under customary norms, with no need for a title deed**; and before that land can be granted to an investor, the law requires a **consulta comunitária**, a mandatory community consultation. Protest and petition are lawful. A project also needs an environmental licence — the **Licença Ambiental**, granted in **three stages** and by **category (A+, A, B, C)** — and, where people are displaced, a **Plano de Reassentamento** (resettlement plan) with its own supervision commission. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. ProSAVANA's collapse did **not** end the pressure on the Nacala Corridor's land — other plantation and agribusiness deals kept advancing in its wake — so in Mozambique a big win stops a flagship project but rarely ends the hunger for land, and a community must keep watch and keep fighting. And this is a **fragile democracy** where the ruling party dominates and defenders can face pressure, so protect your people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A large Mozambican project needs **your land** — so it needs your **DUAT** respected and your **consulta comunitária** consent; it needs its **environmental licence**; and if it displaces you, a lawful **resettlement plan**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and your occupation-based land right is the strongest. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If you occupy the land in good faith, you hold a DUAT even without a title — and the project needs your consent through the consulta comunitária.** That is your sharpest lever.
- **If the consultation was skipped or faked, or the resettlement plan is unlawful, those are real grounds.**
- **If the state and powerful investors are determined, an outright stop is hard — but a transnational, well-organised movement has done it** (ProSAVANA), so aim for withheld consent, a lawful resettlement, exposure, delay — and stay watchful, because the land hunger returns.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **use the rights the land and the law give you** — your DUAT, the consultation, the licence, the resettlement plan — and **run every front at once**, including internationally: the documents, the consultation, the courts, the movement, the press. That's how ProSAVANA was beaten.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

Two things must line up. First, the **land**: an investor needs a DUAT over the land, which the state cannot lawfully grant without a **consulta comunitária** with the affected community — and your own occupation-based DUAT is a prior right. Second, the **environmental licence (Licença Ambiental)**, issued in three stages by the environment authorities, with scrutiny set by the project's **category** (A+ being the most impactful, needing a full environmental impact study, the EPDA scoping stage, and public participation). Where people are displaced, a **Plano de Reassentamento** must be approved and supervised. Local and district authorities and traditional leaders have roles. Know which of these you can grab.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The land and the consulta comunitária. Before land is granted, the community must be consulted. *Your opening — the strongest:* insist the consultation is genuine and inclusive, assert your DUAT, and withhold or condition consent.

The environmental licence. A large project needs the multi-stage licence, with an environmental study and public participation. *Your opening:* take part and attack the study's flaws.

The resettlement plan. If you're to be displaced, the resettlement plan and its supervision commission must follow the law. *Your opening:* a defective or unfair plan is challengeable.

Construction and operation. *Your opening:* breaches of the licence, the consultation, or the resettlement terms.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — including foreign governments and investors, whose home publics can be reached, as Japan's and Brazil's were over ProSAVANA. **What it still needs from you** — your land, your consent, a DUAT: your occupation is the leverage. **What it still lacks** — the

licence not final, the consultation not done, the resettlement not approved: whatever's missing is the soft spot.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment authorities** run the licence. The **consulta comunitária** is where consent is given — make it genuine. The **resettlement supervision commission** oversees displacement. The **courts** can review unlawful grants and plans. And Mozambique's **peasant union (UNAC)**, its **civil-society organisations (like Justiça Ambiental)**, **churches**, and **a press with international reach** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that beat ProSAVANA.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether you hold and assert your DUAT, whether the consultation was genuine, whether you can build a broad (even transnational) movement, and how determined the state and investors are.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Assert your DUAT / withhold consent at the consulta	30–55%	months	low	Land grant blocked, delayed, conditioned
Objections in the environmental licence stages	15–35%	during licensing	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Challenge a defective resettlement plan	20–45%	months–yr	low	Displacement halted or improved
Court challenge (unlawful grant/consultation)	20–45%	1–3 yr	mod	Grant or licence quashed
Movement + press (incl. transnational)	30–55%	months–yr	low	Backers pull out; project collapses (ProSAVANA)
Everything together (your land, movement, world watching)	40–65%	1–4 yr	mod	Blocked, collapsed, conditioned, delayed
Everything together (state/investor-backed)	20–45%	1–4 yr	mod	Delayed; better terms; exposed

The levers that move the needle most are your **DUAT and the consulta comunitária**, and a **broad, even transnational, movement**, backed by the courts and the press. ProSAVANA shows the ceiling (a three-government mega-project collapsed) and the honest floor (the land hunger continued). So aim for the full range — withheld consent, a lawful resettlement, collapse of a flagship project, exposure, delay — and keep watch afterwards.

On cost: asserting your DUAT, taking part in the consultation, and organising are cheap; and your occupation-based land right costs nothing to hold. The great strength is the law's recognition that you own the land you live on — and the great danger is a consultation faked or a movement divided, so guard both.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this DUAT, this faked consultation, this unlawful resettlement — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

- 1. What is it, and who's behind it?** Name the project, the company, and any foreign governments or investors (whose home publics you can reach).
- 2. Whose land is it on, and what does it touch?** Establish that you **occupy it in good faith or under customary norms — so you hold a DUAT**, even without a title — and map it over your farmland, water, forests, and grazing. **Your occupation-based land right is your sharpest lever.**
- 3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is a consulta comunitária due or under way? Is the environmental licence being processed? Is a resettlement plan being drawn up? These openings are time-bound.
- 4. What does it need from you, and what does it still lack?** Your land and consent, the licence, an approved resettlement plan. What it needs from you is your leverage; what it lacks is the soft spot.
- 5. Who else is affected, and who already opposes it?** Neighbouring communities, the peasant union, civil-society organisations, churches. ProSAVANA's power was a whole region — and three countries — organised together.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a plantation is planned on land it has farmed for generations, with a rushed "consultation." The five questions yield: a company and its foreign backers; land you occupy in good faith (your DUAT — your lever); a consultation due or faked; a project that needs your consent; and a coalition of communities, the peasant union, and civil society. That's the ProSAVANA pattern — assert your DUAT, demand a genuine consultation, and build the movement, at home and abroad.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the project rests on — the environmental study and licence, the consulta comunitária record, the resettlement plan, the land grant, the company and investor records. Then read them for flaws — an understated impact, a consultation that never genuinely reached the community, a land grant over your occupied land, a resettlement plan that's unfair or unlawful.

Layer two: the ground truth. Prove your occupation — dated, located photographs and video of your farms, homes, graves, water, and use of the land over time (this establishes your DUAT) — plus the harm the project would do, and the testimony of affected families.

Layer three: the map of occupation and harm. Lay the project over the land your community occupies and uses — your fields, water, forests, and sacred sites — so your prior land right and the harm are undeniable. Walking into the consultation, the environment authorities, or a court with your occupation documented, the study, and that map is what makes them take you seriously.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The environmental study and licence, the consulta comunitária record, the resettlement plan, the land grant** — from the environment authorities, the district administration, and the land services.

- **Proof of your occupation** — photographs, testimony, and records showing your community's use of the land over time (your DUAT).
- **Ownership and financing** — the company and any foreign governments or investors.
- **The occupation-and-harm map** — your fields, water, forests, and sacred sites, laid over the project.
- **Dated site evidence and named testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, and families' statements.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a united community — and, at ProSAVANA's scale, a united movement — gives you power. Build in four moves.

Start with a tight core. The families most affected, the elders who know the land's history, a few tireless organisers, and respected local and traditional figures.

Assert your land right together, and guard against division. Your DUAT is a collective strength; investors and brokers try to split communities and fake "consent." Decide collectively and inclusively at the consulta comunitária, and expose any manufactured consent.

Build the coalition — local, national, and international. ProSAVANA was beaten because UNAC linked with civil society, churches, and academics across Mozambique, Brazil, and Japan, reaching the foreign backers' home publics. Reach the peasant union, national organisations like Justiça Ambiental, and international allies. Hold meetings where people see the evidence.

Build to last, and keep watch. Mozambican fights run for years, and the land hunger returns after a win. Build clear roles, a secure shared archive, an inclusive way to decide together, and a plan for the financial and emotional toll — and a plan to keep watching the corridor after a victory, because the next deal follows.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES, LAND RIGHTS & CONSULTATION

Law here is unusually strong because you hold a land right by occupation, and consultation is mandatory.

Your DUAT and the Consulta Comunitária — Your First and Sharpest Lever

You acquire a **DUAT** — a land-use and benefit right — by **occupying land in good faith or under customary norms, with no title needed**, and it is a prior right the state must respect. Before land is granted to an investor, the law requires a **consulta comunitária**. Insist it is genuine, informed, and inclusive; assert your DUAT; and **withhold or condition consent**. A community asserting its occupation-based land right and refusing a faked consultation is the strongest lever in this guide — and a grant made without a proper consultation is unlawful.

The Environmental Licence and Resettlement

A large project needs the multi-stage **Licença Ambiental**, with an environmental study (the EPDA scoping stage for the biggest, category A+ projects) and public participation — take part and attack its flaws. If you are to be displaced, the **Plano de Reassentamento** and its **supervision commission** must follow the law on fair compensation, adequate land, and restored livelihoods; a defective or unfair plan is a real ground to halt or improve the displacement.

The Courts and the Foreign Backers

An unlawful land grant, a faked consultation, or a defective licence can be challenged in the **courts**. And — the ProSAVANA lever — where **foreign governments or investors** back the project, their home publics and institutions can be reached, and their reputations pressed, sometimes more effectively than the Mozambican state.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: your land right and the consultation are powerful, but the ruling party dominates, consultations are often faked, and a determined state and investor are hard to stop outright. So use the strong tools — the DUAT, the consulta, the licence, the resettlement plan, the courts, the foreign backers — pair them with a broad movement and the press, keep watch after a win, and count withheld consent, a lawful resettlement, a collapsed project, exposure, and delay as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Occupation becomes a land right. Not "we don't want the plantation" but *"we occupy and farm this land in good faith — we hold a DUAT, and it cannot be granted away without our genuine consent."*

A faked consultation becomes an unlawful grant. *"The consulta comunitária never truly reached us — so the land grant is unlawful."*

An unfair resettlement becomes a challenge. *"The resettlement plan offers neither adequate land nor restored livelihoods — it breaches the law."*

The harm becomes a story that travels. *"The land millions of us farm and live on — handed to foreign agribusiness we were never truly asked about."*

Match it to the venue: the DUAT and consent to the consultation; the study's flaws to the licensing; the unfair plan to the resettlement commission and the courts; the unlawful grant to the courts; the human story to the press at home and in the backers' countries.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Mozambique, publicity — especially international — is a powerful lever, because it reaches the foreign governments and investors behind a project, as it reached Japan and Brazil over ProSAVANA. The peasant union, civil society, and a press with international links make the media front central.

Lead with land and people. Not "the consultation was deficient" but "the land millions of us farm and live on, handed to foreign agribusiness we were never truly asked about." Use your strongest material: proof of your occupation, dated photographs, the map of the project over your fields, and community voices.

Work several audiences at once — reach the backers' home publics. Local and national press build domestic pressure; international networks reach the foreign governments and investors, where a project like ProSAVANA is most exposed. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And protect people and unity — let the whole community shape the story, so no one can fake "consent" in your name.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the environment authorities / district).

Subject: Pedido de informação — [projeto].

"We, the community of [place], request the environmental study and licence, the consulta comunitária record, the resettlement plan, and the land grant for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Asserting the DUAT / withholding consent (at the consulta).

Subject: Direito de uso da terra e consentimento — [projeto].

"We, the community of [place], occupy and farm this land in good faith and hold a DUAT over it. We do not consent to [project] on the current terms: [our conditions / objections]. Any grant requires our genuine, informed, collective consent. [Contact.]"

8C — Objection in the environmental licensing.

Subject: Objection — environmental licence for [project].

"We, the community of [place], object to the licence for [project]: [the study understates the harm; the consultation was not genuine]. We ask that the licence be refused or conditioned. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — On a defective resettlement plan.

Subject: Objection — resettlement plan for [project].

"The resettlement plan for [project] offers [inadequate land / no restored livelihoods / unfair compensation], in breach of the law. We ask the supervision commission and the authorities to reject or correct it. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To a lawyer / civil-society organisation.

Subject: Land grab and unlawful consultation — [project].

"Our community faces [project] on land we occupy in good faith, with a faked consultation. We've gathered [proof of occupation, the study, photographs]. We ask for your help to assert our DUAT and challenge the grant and licence. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To a foreign government or investor (backer).

Subject: Land rights and legal concerns in [project], Mozambique.

"We are the community affected by [project] at [location], which your [government / institution] supports. It threatens the land we occupy and farm, without our genuine consent. As with ProSAVANA, this carries real reputational and legal risk. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press (here and abroad).

Subject: Community of [place] acts to protect its land from [project].

"For generations the people of [place] have farmed and lived on this land. Now [project], backed by [foreign backer], threatens it — without our genuine consent. We can provide proof of our occupation, photographs, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the community.

Subject: We hold this land — let's stand as one.

"[Project] threatens our land. Our strength is that the law recognises we own the land we live on — and that we stand together, as ProSAVANA's peasants did across three countries. Let's assert our DUAT, refuse a faked consultation, and decide together. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

- 1. Establish that you occupy the land in good faith — so you hold a DUAT — and prove it.** That's your strongest lever.
- 2. Assert your DUAT and withhold or condition consent at the consulta comunitária (8B) — collectively.**
- 3. Object in the environmental licensing (8C), and request the documents (8A).**
- 4. Photograph everything, with dates and places — your occupation, and the threatened land.**
- 5. Get a lawyer or civil-society ally (8E), and reach the foreign backers (8F).**
- 6. Build the movement, go public at home and abroad (8G/8H) — and keep watch after a win.**

Even lean, those six assert your land right, protect your unity, and open the licensing and international fronts.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Mozambique's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When they fake the consultation. A staged consulta with pro-government associations instead of the real community is a common tactic — and it makes the grant unlawful. Document the fake, and expose it.

When the state and investors are determined. Don't fold: assert your DUAT, build the broadest (even transnational) movement, reach the foreign backers, and aim for withheld consent, a lawful resettlement, and delay.

When the win doesn't end the land hunger. ProSAVANA's collapse didn't stop other deals. Keep watch on the corridor, and keep your coalition ready for the next project.

When defenders face pressure. Take risks seriously, protect the vulnerable, and route danger through organisations, churches, and the press.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Mozambique has serious, documented problems with the capture of land and resource deals, so this matters.

How to spot it. Land grants against communities' occupation rights; faked consultations with pro-government associations; licences against the evidence; benefits to the connected while communities lose their land.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Administrative Tribunal** and audit bodies examine public money. The **anti-corruption office (GCCC)** handles graft. The **courts** can void an unlawful grant or licence. And Mozambique's **civil society (like the CIP), churches, and press** have exposed captured deals.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the process was bent, whose consent was faked, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit and anti-corruption bodies, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the DUAT fight and the international pressure.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents build your proof; your occupation-based land right aims it; a united community and movement are the muscle; the consultation, the licence, and the courts press the case; the media raises the cost at home and abroad. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and remember to keep watch after a win.

Early on (weeks 1–8): establish and prove your DUAT; assert it and withhold consent at the consulta; object in the licensing; request the records; photograph your occupation and the threatened land; build the coalition, local to international.

In the thick of it (months–years): challenge an unlawful grant, a faked consultation, or a defective licence or resettlement plan in the courts; deepen the movement; reach the foreign backers; open the media front here and abroad.

The long haul (years): carry the litigation and the campaign; hold your consent line; hold out for withheld consent, a lawful resettlement, a collapsed project, exposure, or delay — and keep watching the corridor.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Mozambique can be done — a peasant movement spanning three countries defeated a 14-million-hectare agribusiness land grab, and every day communities use the enormous fact that the law recognises they own the land they occupy. Hold both truths. The tools are strong: a DUAT held by occupation in good faith, no title needed; a mandatory consulta comunitária; a multi-stage environmental licence; and a resettlement plan the law must protect. And the constraints are real: a dominant ruling party, faked consultations, determined investors, and a land hunger that returns after a win.

Here's the discipline that wins. Start from your land: prove your occupation, assert your DUAT, and refuse a faked consultation — withhold or condition your consent from a position of right. Object in the environmental licensing, challenge an unfair resettlement, and take an unlawful grant to the courts. Build the broadest movement you can, at home and abroad, and reach the foreign backers, as ProSAVANA's coalition reached Japan and Brazil. Above all, guard your unity, expose faked consent, and keep watch after a win, because the next deal follows. Count withheld consent, a lawful resettlement, a collapsed project, exposure, and delay as wins alongside an outright stop. That's what UNAC and its allies did — the land, the consultation,

and a movement across three countries together. So can you.